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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1966

Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1966 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

Kingalu: A Myth of Origin from Eastern Tanzania

Whichever may be the truth the fact remains that the institution of *ugongo* or *utani* is a most important one in Luguru society. No major ritual occasion such as ancestral rites or mortuary rites can take place without the presence of *wagongo*. It must be fairly clear that in Uluguru, where all the sub-clans live in contiguous areas of relatively fertile land in the mountains, each sub-clan will have such ties to other such units on all sides of it, these ties being regarded in a variety of ways. On the one hand *wagongo* are cousins, but they are also affines (cf. Fox 1967, LEACH 1961 and NEEDHAM 1962). Functionally, of course, these ties must have had an important role in the maintenance of order between the autonomous groups.

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If we turn to the kinship terminology for clues to expected behaviour we are not disappointed. In most respects Luguru terminology is "bifurcate merging" or Iroquois in type, the father and his brothers being called *tata* "father" and being differentiated by *mkulu* „elder" and *mdodo* "younger". Father's sister is called *mamu sangazi*. This could be taken as an interesting case of ambivalent perception since *mamu* is the term applied to the mother, whereas *sangazi* can be shown to derive from terms meaning "female father", as one would expect. She has important functions to play with respect to her brother's daughter at the time of the latter's puberty ceremonies. Since she is the mother of her brother's heir, her son is termed "father" by her brother's children after the brother's decease, although before that time he is given the term of *mtani*, which, as we have already noted, also means joking partner. BEIDELMAN notes of the Kaguru (near neighbors and relations of the Luguru) that there is often an equation made between affinity and the *utani* joking

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relationship (1966: 368). In one sense this is, of course, inevitable with a people practising exogamy and with a matrilineal people we might expect to find that the father is regarded as a kind of affine, which from the point of view the descent group into which he has married, he is (cf. Fox 1967: 165). CHRISTENSEN goes to some pains to emphasize the group nature of *utani/ugongo* (1963: 1314–27), a fact which was confirmed by informants, and which underscores this point. A further expression of the latent hostility which can exist between fathers and sons was demonstrated by the statement of two informants that sons may sometimes accuse their fathers of witchcraft in the event of misfortune, especially to a child, though such accusations would not be made publicly.

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To return briefly to the terminology, elder brothers are given the same term as *sekuru* "grandfathers". A variety of interpretations might be placed on this, perhaps the simplest is that this is an expression of the "merging of alternate generations". The term used to sisters is *lumbu*. According to BEIDELMAN (1967: 29) this term is a reciprocal term used to opposite sex siblings, a fact which has been confirmed as correct in some areas (though not everywhere in Uluguru), which seems strange when one considers the inequivalence of the relationship. Brothers are often said to "rule" their sisters, and sisters ■824 greeting their brothers, even though much younger in age, will always give the Swahili greeting *Shikamoo* "I clasp your feet", which is a very useful pointer to status and role perceptions in this area, since it is invariably used by an inferior to a superior. Women use the kin term *sekuru* to all brothers, whatever age, whereas a man terms his younger brother *mdodo* „little one". Conversely women term their sisters according to age, *mkulu* „elder", *mdodo* „younger". There is clearly some latent tension in the relationship of brothers. While we have seen that a man calls his elder brother by the term which means grandfather, this does not imply at all that one finds the relaxed mild joking relationship found with the actual grandfather. On the contrary, elder brothers are treated with extreme respect, as are their wives, whereas in the reverse direction we find that men have a joking relationship with younger brothers' wives. One might regard this as a situation in which there is some competition for spoils, since normally the elder brother will be the heir apparent to the maternal uncle. The point is mentioned because it has some relevance to the events related in the myth¹².

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¹² That Luguru do see some similarity between grandfathers and elder brothers is evident from the fact that when speaking Swahili they often refer to a grandfather as *kaka* "elder brother", rather than the correct term *babu*. Another possible interpretation of the hostility which exists between brothers might be that it represents a displacement of the hostility felt towards the father, both as a result of unresolved Oedipal tensions, and as the representative of an alien and potentially hostile group. Since in a matrilineal society it would clearly be unthinkable that the son should "replace" the father as he might do in a patrilineal society, this might explain the unusual feature of calling the elder brother by the term meaning grandfather.

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